



BUYER'S GUIDE

Packaging Buyer's Guide for Sri Lankan Brands

A plain-language guide for marketing, procurement and founders who buy printed packaging: which structure to choose, what to specify, what drives cost, and how to brief a printer so the first run is right.

1. The three families of boxes

Factor	Folding carton	Rigid box	Corrugated
Made from	250–450 gsm board, die-cut, glued, ships flat	1.5–3 mm greyboard wrapped in printed paper	Fluted board, 3-ply or 5-ply
Best for	Retail shelf: tea, cosmetics, pharma, food	Gifting, jewellery, premium tea, sets	Shipping, e-commerce, export, food delivery
Unit cost	Low	High	Low–medium
Minimum order	50 digital / 500 offset	100	100–500
Print	Excellent, any finish	Excellent, foil and textures	Flexo (good) or litho-laminated (excellent)

2. Choosing a folding carton style

- **Straight tuck end (STE):** both flaps tuck the same way. Cosmetics, pharma, electronics.
- **Reverse tuck end (RTE):** flaps tuck opposite ways, slightly cheaper. Everyday retail.
- **Crash-lock (auto) bottom:** base locks when opened. Heavier products, fast packing lines, bottles.
- **Sleeve and tray:** premium feel, easy to hand-pack. Tea, chocolates, gift sets.
- **Display / counter unit:** perforated tear-off front. Cash-and-carry and pharmacy counters.
- **Window carton:** PET or PLA window shows the product. Bakery, textiles, toys.

3. Board and material

Board	Use	Notes
FBB / SBS 250–350 gsm	Most retail cartons	White both sides, prints beautifully, food-safe virgin grades available

FBB 350–450 gsm © PrintPack Lanka · Free resource, share freely	Heavier products, premium feel	Adds rigidity and cost www.printpacklanka.lk
Duplex 250–400 gsm	Inner packs, budget cartons	Grey back, lower cost, not for food contact
Kraft 250–350 gsm	Natural / eco look	Brown, muted colours, pairs with one-colour print
E-flute corrugated	Cake boxes, pizza, mailers	Strong and light, print on white top liner
BC-flute 5-ply	Export master cartons	Specify ECT/BCT for freight

4. Finishes and what they cost

- **Aqueous / varnish:** low cost, light protection, matt or gloss.
- **Lamination:** scuff and moisture resistance; matt, gloss or soft-touch. Adds 10–20%.
- **Spot UV:** glossy highlights on a matt base. Adds a pass; economical at volume.
- **Hot foil:** gold, silver, holographic; needs a die. Premium signal.
- **Embossing / debossing:** raised or recessed logos; needs a die.
- **Window patching:** film applied inside the window; food-grade PLA available.

5. What drives the price

Print has high fixed costs (plates, make-ready, die) and low running costs, so unit price falls steeply with quantity. The five main levers:

1. **Quantity:** ask for prices at three quantities and pick the sweet spot.
2. **Sheet utilisation:** a few millimetres can change how many boxes fit on a sheet.
3. **Board weight and grade.**
4. **Colours:** CMYK is standard; each Pantone adds a plate; inside printing adds a pass.
5. **Finishing:** each finish adds set-up and a machine pass.

Typical 2026 ranges in Sri Lanka (4-colour, 300 gsm, excluding VAT):

Folding cartons LKR 25–120 · Labels LKR 2–20 · Corrugated mailers LKR 90–350 · Rigid boxes LKR 350–1,500. Real quotes depend on size, quantity and finish.

6. Nine ways to cut cost without cutting quality

- Order the annual quantity in two or three drops instead of monthly small runs.
- Standardise box sizes across SKUs so one die serves many products.
- Use CMYK plus one spot colour rather than three spot colours.
- Print inside the box in one colour.
- Use aqueous coating instead of lamination where scuffing is not an issue.
- Drop 50 gsm if a crash-lock base gives the strength you need.
- Ask about house-stock papers.
- Approve artwork once, then reorder from archived files.
- Launch on digital under 500 units, then switch to offset.

7. Compliance checklist

- **Food contact:** virgin board, low-migration inks, declaration of compliance for export.
- **Mandatory text:** product name, net weight, ingredients, origin, best-before, batch, manufacturer/importer, nutrition where required, SLS marks where applicable.
- **Barcodes:** GS1 EAN-13 on retail units, ITF-14 on shippers; verify before print.
- **Pharma:** NMRA-approved artwork, braille where required, batch/expiry areas, line clearance.
- **Tea:** Sri Lanka Tea Board Lion logo rules for pure Ceylon tea.
- **Sustainability claims:** only state FSC or recycled content if the material is certified.

8. How to brief a printer

Give	Why
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Product dimensions or a sample	Determines the dieline and sheet utilisation
Quantity (or several)	Sets the print method and price curve
Deadline and delivery address	Schedules press time and freight
Reference images or competitor packs	Communicates the look faster than words
Artwork or brand guidelines	Lets prepress start immediately
Compliance needs	Food contact, export market, buyer spec

The process you should expect

1. Costed proposal within one working day
2. Free dieline and white sample to test fit
3. Artwork preflight and proof for approval
4. Production with quality checks
5. Delivery, files archived for reorder

Need it printed? Send this to PrintPack Lanka for a costed proposal within one working day, with a free dieline and sample for packaging.

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